the Ganges, and southwards across the Vindhya mountains till the Godavari river on the Deccan plateau. There were powerful and not-so-powerful kings, aggrandizing rulers who were aspirants to the appellation ‘chief king of all kings’, and powerful confederate clans.[1] Over a relatively short period of time—roughly coinciding with the domination of Athens in the classical period—a large part of this profusion of political entities was absorbed into a single imperial realm. Centred in Magadha, which was based in the middle Gangetic plains of Bihar, a succession of kings ruled over this empire straddling large parts of India. The first of these imperial houses was that of the Nandas. They were followed by the Mauryas. From the fourth century BCE till the advent of Ashoka (*c*. 269/268 BCE), there were said to have been eleven such imperial monarchs,[2] nine in the Nanda dynasty, followed by the two Maurya kings who preceded Ashoka: Chandragupta, founder of the dynasty (Ashoka’s grandfather, who overthrew the Nandas), followed by Bindusara, Ashoka’s father.

But though king succeeded king and one century followed another, the only evidence of those times are versions of them—some accurate, others fanciful, and practically never contemporary—that have survived. These remaining records of those times are the *Puranas*, certain Buddhist and Jaina texts, and histories of a sort by people who are referred to as ‘classical authors’—mainly literate companions in Alexander’s entourage—as also the famous Megasthenes who visited the court of Chandragupta. These sources provide us with nearly all the information that we now have of India’s rulers and states in that antique time. The rulers themselves failed to speak to their subjects, and therefore to us. Many of their names, and of their principalities, are known: Janaka of Videha, Pasenadi of Kosala, the Magadha monarch Bimbisara, and Pradyota of Avanti are some. But how such kings defined their domains and powers, how they appeared to their subjects, what they and their queens donated, and what kind of worship prevailed in their courts—these remain hidden because no royal epigraphs